Elton Eduardo Freitas

Postdoctoral Researcher, Center for Collective Learning, IAST, Toulouse School of Economics
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Economist working on the economics of productive transformation and regional development: how firms, productive capabilities, market structures and production networks shape the economic transformation of cities and regions, and how industrial and place-based policies can foster productivity, diversification and inclusive development. I combine large-scale Brazilian administrative data (RAIS, SECEX, CAGED), applied econometrics and economic complexity, with over 15 years of experience across academia, government and industry.

Academic positions

2026-2027	**Postdoctoral Researcher**, Center for Collective Learning, Institute for Advanced Study in Toulouse (IAST), Toulouse School of Economics, France Subnational economic complexity across geographic scales, with data from Brazil, Spain and Mexico. Expected end: April 2027.
2022-now	**Associate Professor (Professor Adjunto)**, Department of Economics and Graduate Programme in Economics (PPGE), Federal University of Sergipe, Brazil Regional Economics and Industrial Economics, undergraduate and graduate; supervision of student research.
2022-now	**Visiting Researcher**, CEDEPLAR, Federal University of Minas Gerais, Brazil
2021-2022	**Substitute Lecturer**, Federal University of Minas Gerais (also 2016-2017)
2010-2015	**Lecturer**, FEAD Centro de Gestão Empreendedora, Belo Horizonte

Education

2019	**PhD in Economics**, CEDEPLAR, Federal University of Minas Gerais Thesis: *Related industries, economic complexity and regional diversification: an application for Brazilian microregions*. UFMG Thesis Award, best thesis in economics (2020).
2012	**MSc in Economics**, CEDEPLAR, Federal University of Minas Gerais Thesis: external economies, urban attributes and productivity in Brazilian microregions, 2000-2010.
2008	**BSc in Economics**, Federal University of Ceará, Magna Cum Laude

Peer-reviewed publications

2026	Queiroz, A., **Freitas, E.** and Romero, J. P. **Economic complexity and local employment multipliers.** *Structural Change and Economic Dynamics* 76: 20-43. doi.org/10.1016/j.strueco.2025.11.005
2025	Silveira, F., Romero, J. P., Queiroz, A., **Freitas, E.** and Stein, A. **Economic complexity and deforestation in the Brazilian Amazon.** *World Development* 185: 106804. doi.org/10.1016/j.worlddev.2024.106804
2024	**Freitas, E.**, Britto, G. and Amaral, P. **Related industries, economic complexity, and regional diversification: an application for Brazilian microregions.** *Papers in Regional Science* 103: 100011. doi.org/10.1016/j.pirs.2024.100011
2024	Romero, J. P., **Freitas, E.**, Silveira, F., Britto, G., Cimini, F. and Jayme Jr., F. **Complexity-based diversification strategies: a new method for ranking promising activities for regional diversification.** *Spatial Economic Analysis* 20(4): 640-663. doi.org/10.1080/17421772.2024.2384744
2024	Ribeiro, L. C., Santos, F., De Moura, F., Montenegro, R. and **Freitas, E. Determinants of tourist employment in Brazilian microregions: a dynamic panel data approach.** *Journal of Regional Science* 64: 1622-1646. doi.org/10.1111/jors.12723

2024 Queiroz, A., Romero, J. P. and **Freitas, E. Relatedness and regional economic complexity: good news for some, bad news for others.** *EconomiA* 25: 264-288. doi.org/10.1108/econ-11-2023-0185

2024 Lopes, C., Romero, J. P. and **Freitas, E. Smart diversification strategies differentiated by countries' complexity.** *CEPAL Review* 143: 127-147. doi.org/10.18356/16840348-2024-143-7

2023 Queiroz, A., Romero, J. P. and **Freitas, E. Economic complexity and employment in Brazilian states.** *CEPAL Review* 139: 177-196. doi.org/10.18356/16840348-2023-139-9

2019 Britto, G., Romero, J. P., **Freitas, E.** and Coelho, C. **The great divide: economic complexity and development paths in Brazil and the Republic of Korea.** *CEPAL Review* 127: 191-213. doi.org/10.18356/d06fff2f-en

2017 Gala, P., Camargo, J. and **Freitas, E. The Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean (ECLAC) was right: scale-free complex networks and core-periphery patterns in world trade.** *Cambridge Journal of Economics* 42: 633-651. doi.org/10.1093/cje/bex057

Ongoing research projects

2025-now **Lithium batteries in Brazil: markets, impact and feasibility of a plant**. Researcher (R&D fellow). SENAI/PE, Rota 2030 programme.

2026-2027 **Update of the Regional Development Plan for the Northeast (PRDNE 2028-2031)**. Member; coordinator of Axis 1, Productive Development. Led by J. P. Romero, Cedeplar/UFMG; SUDENE.

2026-2027 **Observatory of the New Industry Brazil in the Northeast (DataNordeste panel)**. Member. SUDENE.

2024-2026 **Textile supply chain in Sergipe**. Coordinator. FAPITEC/SE.

2024-now **Green and inclusive smart diversification strategies**. Member. Coordinated by J. P. Romero, CEDEPLAR/UFMG.

2024-now **DataViva: productive development and social transformation**. Technical coordinator. Led by G. Britto; FAPEMIG.

Policy and professional experience

2021-2022 **Competitive Intelligence Product Manager**, Industry Observatory, Federation of Industries of Ceará (FIEC)
Led the portfolio of sectoral and economic studies for Ceará's industrial strategy and the use of quantitative methods.

2020-2021 **Business Analyst**, Euvaldo Lodi Institute (IEL/FIEMG)
Sectoral and market research and strategic intelligence for industrial firms.

2019-2020 **Technical Adviser**, State Audit Court of Minas Gerais (TCE-MG)
Advised on the creation of a public policy evaluation unit.

2017-2019 **Consultant, Development and Research**, Gove
Studies on economic development, productive diversification and complexity; georeferenced data platforms for public and social-impact decisions.

2017 **Technical Adviser, Market Intelligence**, INDI, Minas Gerais investment and trade agency
Built the Strategic Market Map for Minas Gerais exports.

2013-2017 **DataViva**, Government of Minas Gerais (Office of Strategic Priorities) and FAPEMIG
Managed development and content of dataviva.info, an open platform of Brazilian economic data, with César Hidalgo's team; defined its economic models and business rules.

2019-now **Consultant**, Fundação IPEAD
Studies for Sebrae/MG, CGEE, the City of Belo Horizonte and federal ministries.

Awards and distinctions

2026 **FIEMG Economics Prize**, 2nd place, with Y. N. Santos and G. Britto

2026 **ABEIN Paper Prize in Industrial Economics and Innovation**, 2nd place, X ENEI

2020	**UFMG Thesis Award**, best thesis, Graduate Programme in Economics
2015	**CNI Economics Prize**, 1st place, Brazilian Industry category
2015	**19th Banco do Nordeste Regional Economics Prize**, 3rd place
2012	**CNI Economics Prize**, 1st place
2012	**17th Brazil Economics Prize**, 2nd place, Federal Council of Economics
2012	**16th Regional Economics Prize**, 3rd place, master's dissertation category, Banco do Nordeste and ANPEC
2009	**Magna Cum Laude**, Federal University of Ceará
2008	**12th BNB Regional Economics Prize**, 2nd place, professional category
2008	**Germana Amaral de Morais Prize**, 1st place, 27th Scientific Initiation Meeting, UFC

Skills and languages

- **Methods:** applied econometrics and causal inference (panel data, difference-in-differences, shift-share), economic complexity, network and spatial analysis.
- **Data:** Brazilian administrative and trade microdata (RAIS, CAGED, SECEX, Census, Base dos Dados); reproducible pipelines.
- **Management and communication:** leading multidisciplinary teams; agile project management (Scrum); economic planning and public policy; presenting results in talks and media interviews.
- **Software:** Python, R, Stata, SQL/BigQuery, Neo4j; D3Plus, Power BI.
- **Languages:** Portuguese (native), English (full professional proficiency).
- **Referee for:** World Development, Journal of Regional Science, Spatial Economic Analysis, EPJ Data Science, among others.

References available on request. Updated November 2026.